

A culturally inspired, off-grid smart community beacon:

In Guinea, the Nimba is understood as a powerful maternal and cultural symbol associated with fertility, abundance, protection, women's strength, wisdom, and communal prosperity. In Baga tradition, it is often described as the "Great Mother" or the spirit of mature womanhood, appearing in ceremonies tied to harvest, planting, weddings, births, and other moments when the community affirms life and continuity.

What makes Nimba especially meaningful is that it is not just an artwork or ornament; it is a public cultural presence. It represents the ideal of a strong woman who nurtures life, sustains growth, and inspires collective wellbeing, and it is deeply tied to social identity and agricultural blessing in Guinean culture.

Embedding Nimba into the infrastructure is powerful because it transforms a technical object into a cultural guardian. Instead of a light post feeling like a foreign utility, the totem becomes something people can recognize as belonging to their own identity, memory, and values. That helps the infrastructure feel trusted, respected, and socially shared rather than distant or purely mechanical.

For the community, seeing Nimba in the totem can represent several things at once: protection in moments of danger, abundance in moments of peace, and solidarity in moments of crisis. It can say that the community is being watched over that women and children are valued, that life is being sustained, and that people should come together around the totem not only for light or warnings, but for gathering, mutual support, and collective resilience.

In this project, the Nimba form is doing more than beautifying the infrastructure. It is giving the flood-warning totem a deeper civic and emotional meaning: it becomes a sign of shared life, shared protection, and shared responsibility.

Visual colour meaning

Each colour should not only indicate a technical system status but also carry a social message about what the community should feel, understand, and do.

Colour associations

- **Green** can represent safety, stability, solidarity, and normal community life. In relation to the Guinea flag, green also reflects the land, agriculture, prosperity, and the shared strength of the people. When the totem glows green, it tells the community that conditions are calm, the system is functioning normally, and daily life can continue with confidence.
- **Yellow** can represent attention, generosity, awareness, and readiness. It reflects the Guinea flag's meaning of energy, equality, and the radiance of the sun. When the totem shifts to yellow, it should signal that something is changing and the community should stay alert, prepare, and observe closely.

- **Red** can represent urgency, protection, collective effort, and response. In the flag, red carries the memory of sacrifice, labour, and the struggle for progress. On the totem, red should mean immediate action: flood risk is high, danger is present, and the community must gather, protect one another, and move carefully.
- **Blue** remains the dedicated flood-warning colour, especially for heavy rain or water-related danger. It can symbolize water itself, rainfall, and a specific flood alert state distinct from the flag-based civic colours. Blue is the moment when the totem says the weather has turned serious and the community must respond quickly and together.

What each colour should prompt

- **Green:** Continue normal activity, meet around the totem, feel reassured, and use the space safely.
- **Yellow:** Pay attention, check the sky and surroundings, prepare belongings, warn family members, and stay close to updates.
- **Red:** Act now, protect property, move children and elders, avoid risky areas, and support neighbours.
- **Blue:** Flood alert, heavy rain warning, immediate caution around water, and collective readiness for possible evacuation or emergency response.

Flag and community meaning:

By connecting the light colours to the Guinea flag, the totem becomes more than an emergency signal. It becomes a civic symbol that reflects work, justice, and solidarity while also turning those values into practical behaviour. The colours remind people that safety is collective, not individual, and that the community must respond together when conditions change.

This also makes the totem emotionally legible. People do not only see a colour; they understand a message about their shared life, their environment, and their responsibility to one another. In this way, the lights become a form of public storytelling: green for belonging, yellow for readiness, red for action, and blue for flood danger.

The Nimba Totem uses colour as a shared community language. Green means calm, safety, and solidarity, echoing the Guinea flag's meaning of land, prosperity, and collective belonging. Yellow means attention and readiness, reminding people to prepare and stay aware as conditions change. Red means urgency and collective action, calling the community to protect one another when danger rises. Blue remains the special flood-warning colour, signalling heavy rain and water risk. Together, these colours transform light into public meaning: they guide behaviour, strengthen awareness, and remind the community that protection, vigilance, and solidarity are shared responsibilities.